

4.6 Option 4: The World of Cultural Diversity

Culture

Culture is a complex concept, with multiple meanings but universal importance to human populations. In many parts of the world consumption is the dominant, but not the only, culture. Culture varies spatially and has a distinct geography, with some areas being relatively homogenous while others offer greater diversity. Large urban areas often produce diversity, which is reflected in the population, services and built environment of cities. Attitudes to cultural diversity differ, both personal and political/national.

Cultural patterns

Globalisation is seen by some as a key process in driving culture towards a global model, and media TNCs and communications technology aid this process. However, the pattern is complex and localised cultures do survive and new cultures can still be generated. Culture, to some extent, determines our attitude to the wider environment in terms of consumption, conservation, exploitation and protection. Attitudes to the environment differ between cultures; however the dominance of today's consumer capitalism is difficult to resolve with pressing global environmental concerns.

Global synoptic context

Key linkages

Places

How do cultural landscapes vary?

People

How do cultures vary?

Power

Is there a 'global culture'?

Suggested teaching and learning

Collecting a series of photographs of urban and rural landscapes from around the world and locating these on map

Using the internet to research the factors that might have led to these different cultural landscapes

Examining websites, such as McDonalds and mapping the distribution of outlets.

1 Defining culture and identifying its value

Enquiry question: *What is the nature and value of culture in terms of peoples and places?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ Definitions of culture, in terms of human cultures (ethnicities, beliefs, histories) and places (the production of cultural landscapes); the complex origins of the word 'culture'.	■ Exploring different definitions of culture and the reasons why culture is such a complex concept, which is challenging to define.

■ There is a range of human cultures and a variety of cultural landscapes linked to these, which continually change and evolve.	■ Investigating the range of human cultures, their shared characteristics, attitudes, beliefs and values, and the links between culture and landscape; via contrasting examples of traditional cultural landscapes versus post-modern technoscapes and ethnoscapes for instance.
■ Some cultures and landscapes are more vulnerable than others from environmental, socio-economic and political pressures.	■ Investigating the threats for instance erosion/destruction of landscapes and culture via political actions (Tibet) or socio-economic pressures (tourism in Bhutan; post-productivist EU landscapes).
■ The cultural diversity of people and places is valued, and protected, to different degrees by different players. An in-depth study of culture and its landscape should be used to illustrate this variation.	■ Examining the value placed on diversity by different players and groups, and exploring the reasons for their concepts of value through examples such as Wales.

2 The geography of culture

Enquiry question: *How and why does culture vary spatially?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ Some countries and regions are culturally more homogenous than others, for instance Japan and Iceland in contrast with the UK; both human and physical factors help explain this.	■ Developing an understanding of how factors such as geographical isolation and rates of social and economic development have influenced degrees of cultural diversity.
■ Human cultural diversity is usually greatest in cities and in many societies there is a clear urban/rural cultural divide.	■ Investigating how and why urban areas are frequently cultural gateways (eg London or Los Angeles), that have greater cultural diversity than surrounding rural areas.

■ Government and other players' attitudes, both positive and negative, towards human diversity and landscape diversity, are important in preserving diversity or moving towards cultural homogeneity.	■ Weighing up the role of governments and other players through contrasting case studies, such as Tibet, versus the preservation of landscapes in Israel.
■ On a global scale, cultural imperialism ('McDonaldisation' and other similar processes) is an important but not yet complete process affecting both human cultural diversity and the production of landscapes.	■ Examining the mechanisms of cultural imperialism, and the counter-cultures and movements which work against it, such as movements in France and the Arab world.

3 The impact of globalisation on cultural diversity

Enquiry question: *How is globalisation impacting on culture?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ Views vary greatly as to the significance of globalisation on cultural diversity.	■ Contrasting the variety of opinions from the pessimistic hyperglobalisers through to the sceptics.
■ The role of the global media corporations is important in conveying dominant cultural values and attitudes, and influencing cultural globalisation.	■ Examining the dominant world view that media corporations, such as Disney and Viacom convey, and how these may conflict with local values.
■ Cultural globalisation often takes place in local contexts thus giving rise to distinctive hybrid, globalised forms of fashion, music and film.	■ Investigating the variety of localised forms of culture, such as Bollywood, and the emergence of new forms of expression such as internet language, blogs and interactive web media.
■ There are many different opinions about the impact of a globalised consumerist society on the culture of peoples and landscapes.	■ Investigating the impacts of consumerism, both positive and negative, on peoples and their landscapes.

4 Cultural attitudes to the environment

Enquiry question: *How do cultural values impact on our relationship with the environment?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ Different cultures have developed different definitions of, and attitudes to, the environment.	■ Exploring differences in the relationship between humans and nature using a range of societies and political ideologies.
■ These different attitudes affect the way in which the landscape is valued in terms of exploitation and protection.	■ Investigating why different cultural values affect human's use of the environment; and how key terms, such as sustainability, are defined differently according to cultural norms.
■ Anthropocentric cultural values are necessary to support and justify consumer cultures.	■ Examining how continued, growing consumption (as in modern China) requires humans to see themselves as dominant over physical and ecological aspects of the broader cultural landscape.
■ There is a clear conflict between environmentalism and consumer capitalism. Various cultural devices have emerged to attempt to resolve this conflict, for instance the 'green' movement.	■ Investigating the uneasy relationship between the culture of consumerism and concerns about biodiversity loss, global warming and environmental change.

Suggested fieldwork opportunities for the world of cultural diversity

Local fieldwork ■ Urban fieldwork in a major city, exploring the cultural characteristics of areas with distinct ethnicities. ■ Cultural landscapes in the UK could be compared, for instance the in Wales, Cornwall and the Western Isles.	Residential and long-haul fieldwork ■ Relatively close areas have very distinct cultural landscapes, such as Catalonia and the Basque country, Brittany or border zones in Ireland/Wales. ■ There may be opportunities for exchange visits to places further
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